

Through Singapore's vignettes: Witnessing the crowning of a chess king

The Indian diaspora and global spectators witness history, marking a **triumphant moment** for Indian chess on the world stage.

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December 12. It is a quiet evening at Hotel Equarius, the venue of the World chess championship at World Resorts Sentosa. The 14th game is heading towards an inevitable draw, and you, like everybody else, are prepared to come back on Friday for the tiebreaks, as the score is going to be 7-7 after the last of the classical games. But, in a moment, it is all over.

Ding Liren has blundered. He is in a completely lost position. Incredible as it may sound, D. Gukesh is the youngest chess champion in history, which dates back to 1886. All the reporters rush to catch the bus to the adjacent venue, a convention centre, where the press conference is held every day. It is moderated by Maurice Ashley, who made history himself by becoming the first black Grandmaster. There are still only four of them, 25 years after Ashley's feat. Both his siblings, Alicia and Devon, are World champions in boxing.

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At the press conference, a reporter can usually ask one question. I ask Gukesh about his Seconds (players who assist in training using their vast knowledge and expertise in certain areas). One name he says takes everyone by surprise: Vincent Keymer. The friendly young

man from Germany is 20, as is his World ranking. He was the World No. 12 at the beginning of the year. He himself should be nurturing ambitions of becoming the World champion one day.

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The venue of the World championship is a small island called Sentosa, off the southern coast of mainland Singapore. It is promoted as a luxurious — read, frightfully expensive — tourist destination. To reach there, you have to get on to an underground train, get off at the Harbourfront station, then travel by monorail from the roof of a shopping mall, and after travelling up in the air for three minutes, you will have to take a shuttle bus — you can also walk, but it is not an exciting prospect in the heat and humidity — to reach Equarius Hotel.

The public transport system is excellent in Singapore and way more affordable than cabs (there is no Uber here; the business was sold to Grab six years ago). The